



WEEK ONE · MODULE ONE

The World You Are Entering

Who these families really are, and what they are actually buying

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

Read the module once, without notes, to build the shape of it.

Read it a second time with the self-assessment in front of you.

Complete Module 2 (the cases) only after the second reading.

Bring to your mentorship session the one passage you disagreed with. There will be one.

CHAPTER I

The field

What private service is, and what it is not

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Define private service and distinguish it from hospitality, from the concierge industry, and from domestic staffing.

Situate the profession historically, and understand why it re-emerged.

Use the vocabulary of the field correctly, from the first day.

1.1 · A definition

Private service is the profession of running the personal life of a wealthy individual or family, from inside their trust rather than inside an institution. It is not a job in an industry with published prices, standard hours and an HR department. It is a relationship, formalised by a contract, and it lives or dies on a quality that cannot be audited: whether you can be relied upon absolutely.

DEFINITION

Private service. The direct employment of an individual by a private household or its family office, to manage some part of the principal's personal life, logistics, residences, staff, travel, projects, or the whole of it, under conditions of confidentiality.

The word **private** is the whole of it. Everything else in your working life so far has been public in some degree: a hotel, a restaurant, a shop, an office. There was a brand between you and the guest, and the brand carried the standard. Here there is no brand. There is you, and there is a family, and the standard is whatever you personally are.

1.2 · What it is not

Four professions are routinely confused with this one, including by people who work in them. The confusion is not academic: each of the four hires differently, pays differently, and rewards different behaviour.

Adjacent field	How it differs
Hotel concierge (<i>Les Clefs d'Or</i>)	Employed by a property, serving many guests, briefly. Rewarded for visible excellence and for the memorable gesture. The guest leaves; the relationship is transactional and warm. Excellent training, and a poor set of instincts to carry unexamined into a private house.
Concierge company (<i>membership businesses</i>)	A company sells a subscription to a pool of clients and serves them through a team. You serve requests, not a person. The relationship belongs to the company, not to you, and the client can be handed to a colleague at any moment.
Domestic staffing	Housekeeping, cooking, driving, childcare. Essential, honourable, and organised around the maintenance of the house rather than the management of a life. Different skill, different ladder.
Executive assistance	Serving a person, but in their professional capacity. The boundary between the two is thin, and in private service it is routinely crossed, in one direction only: the private role absorbs professional tasks far more often than the reverse.

1.3 · A short history, and why it matters

The great European household of the nineteenth century was an organisation of thirty or fifty people, with a butler at its head, a codified hierarchy, and a career structure. It collapsed in the twentieth century, two wars, taxation, and the disappearance of a servant class that had no alternative. By 1960 the profession was widely believed to be finished.

It returned, and it returned changed. The wealth created from the 1980s onward, finance, technology, energy, and later the emerging economies, produced a very large number of people who possessed extraordinary means and no inherited system for living with them. They did not want a household of forty. They wanted **one person who could make everything work**, and they were prepared to pay unusual sums for it.

That is the role you are training for. Understand its lineage, because it explains its habits: the vocabulary is inherited from the old world (*principal, butler, livery*), and the expectations belong to the new one (speed, mobility, technology, absolute discretion in an age when everything leaks). You are, in a real sense, a modern profession wearing an old uniform. Both halves of that sentence matter.

1.4 · One craft, several names

Before anything else, a piece of vocabulary that will save you months of confusion, and that almost nobody explains.

This profession does not have one title. It has five or six, and they describe the same craft. Depending on the house, the country and the size of the operation, you will be called a private concierge, a lifestyle manager, a personal assistant, a house manager or an estate manager. The name on the contract changes. What you actually do does not: you look after the private life of one family, with discretion, anticipation and standards.

The title	What it usually means, in practice
Private concierge · Lifestyle manager	You look after the person . Their time, their travel, their requests, their life outside work. The purest expression of this craft, and the title most used in Europe and in the press.
Personal assistant · Executive PA	The same work, described in the language of the office. Calendar, correspondence, travel, personal affairs. This is the title you will see most often in an agency listing.
House manager	You look after the house . Suppliers, budgets, standards, staff, the physical running of one residence.
Estate manager	The same, at a larger scale. Several residences, real budgets, real teams. A senior step, reached after years.
Chief of staff	Both, across everything. The summit of a private-service career.

THE PRACTICAL CONSEQUENCE, AND IT MATTERS THIS WEEK

When you search for a role, search for **all of these words**, and not only the one that brought you here.

An agency will very rarely advertise a "private concierge". It will advertise a personal assistant, a house manager, an executive PA. It is the same craft, the same house, the same principal, and the same skills you are learning here. The person who only searches for one word finds almost nothing, and concludes that the market is closed. It is not. She was looking for the wrong noun.

1.5 · The vocabulary, from day one

Term	Use
Principal	The person you serve. Never "boss", never "client", never "employer". The word signals immediately that you know where you are.
Household	The residence and the people who run it. Not "the house" when you mean the organisation.

Term	Use
The office	Shorthand for the family office. “I’ll confirm with the office” is one of the most useful sentences you will ever learn.
UHNWI	Ultra-high-net-worth individual. Used in the industry and in agency briefs; never used in front of the principal.
Live-in / live-out	Whether accommodation is provided on the estate. It changes the job, the pay and the life. Ask early.
Rota	The staff schedule. In a serious household it is a document, not an understanding.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Private service is a relationship, not an industry role. There is no brand between you and the family.

It is not hotel concierge work, not a membership company, not domestic staffing, not executive assistance, though it borrows from all four.

The profession is old in vocabulary and new in expectation. Both halves shape how you are judged.

CHAPTER II

A working taxonomy of wealth

Because a role at \$50M and a role at \$2B share a title and nothing else

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Distinguish the tiers of private wealth, and what each means for your daily work.

Recognise how the *source* of a fortune shapes the culture of the household.

Ask, at interview, the two questions that reveal what the job actually is.

2.1 · The tiers

“Wealthy” is not a category. It is a ladder, and each rung is a different profession for you. This is not snobbery; it determines who employs you, what you do all day, who you report to, and what you are paid.

Tier	The household, and your role in it
HNW \$1M to \$30M	One home, perhaps a second. Possibly a housekeeper and a nanny. A concierge, if any, is part-time and blended with other duties. There is no family office. This is not your market , and a role here will not teach you this profession.
VHNW / lower UHNW \$30M to \$250M	Two to five residences. A small team: house manager, housekeeper, nanny, sometimes a chauffeur. Travel is private but often chartered. The family still decides most things personally, and you will speak to them daily. This is where most private concierge and lifestyle-manager roles live , and it is the best place to learn, because you will touch everything.
Upper UHNW \$250M to \$1B	A structured operation. A family office exists. Above you sits an estate manager or a chief of staff. Aircraft owned rather than chartered, often a yacht. Security is a standing function. Roles are specialised: you will not do everything, and you will be measured on your own lane.
Billionaire	An institution. Dozens of staff across many properties, layers of governance, legal, communications, philanthropy, and a security apparatus. Vetting is serious and slow. You may not meet the principal for months, and you may serve them for years without a personal conversation. Extremely well paid, extremely constrained.

2.2 · The source of the fortune shapes the house

This is the kind of distinction that separates a practitioner from a beginner, and it is almost never written down. Two families of identical wealth can be entirely different employers, and the difference is usually where the money came from.

Source	The culture it produces
Inherited / old money	Understatement, patina, institutions, tradition. Staff are often long-serving, and the household has a memory. They notice codes acutely and forgive extravagance not at all. They will judge you on manners before competence. The pay is often below market; the tenure is long, and the reference is gold.
Entrepreneurial / first generation	Speed, informality, impatience, and a certain suspicion of ceremony. Decisions are instant and reversed without embarrassment. They pay well and expect to be answered at any hour. The risk is boundary collapse: with no inherited model of staff, they may treat you as a friend, then as an employee again, within the same week.
Finance	Process, metrics, reporting, delegation. They will want a system, and they will be pleased when you produce one. They understand professional distance and generally maintain it. Bonuses are real, and expectations during deal periods are absolute.
Technology	Youth, informality, unconventional hours, a horror of visible hierarchy, combined with an extreme, almost paranoid attention to privacy and data. Expect NDAs of unusual severity, device policies, and a distaste for anything that looks like ceremony.
Royal / GCC households	Scale, protocol, strict hierarchy, and gender-segregated staffing in some houses. Discretion is not a preference but a legal and cultural absolute. Extremely generous packages; a demanding and highly formal environment; an expectation that you understand religious and cultural observance without being told.
Celebrity / entertainment	Chaotic calendars, intense media exposure, and an entourage whose loyalties are unclear. Discretion is tested weekly rather than yearly. Tenure is short, and the greatest professional risk in the whole field of private service sits here.

2.3 · The two questions

You are permitted to ask them at interview, and you should. They are not impertinent; they are the questions a professional asks.

ASK, ALWAYS

“How many residences?” This tells you the true scale of the work, the travel, and the complexity of the logistics.

“How many staff, and who would I report to?” This tells you whether you are the operation or a part of it, and it reveals the chain of command before you are inside it.

Two numbers and one name. They describe the job more accurately than any job description you will ever be sent.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The tier of wealth determines the shape of the job more than the job title does.

Most concierge and lifestyle-manager roles sit between \$30M and \$250M, and that band is the best classroom.

The source of the fortune predicts the culture: old money judges manners; first-generation wealth erodes boundaries; tech obsesses over data; royal households formalise everything.

Two questions at interview, residences and staff, reveal the truth of the role.

CHAPTER III

The family office

The chain of command, and how it breaks

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Describe the structure of a single- and multi-family office.

Identify who signs, who decides, and whose trust must be won.

Handle a contradiction between the principal and the office without being blamed by either.

3.1 · What it is

DEFINITION

Family office. A private structure established to manage the wealth and affairs of one family (a single-family office, SFO) or several (a multi-family office, MFO). Its remit typically includes investments, tax, legal, property, philanthropy, and, critically for you, the employment, payroll and contracts of household staff.

Above roughly a quarter of a billion, a family ceases to be a household and becomes an organisation with a head office. The consequences for you are immediate and practical: the person who interviews you may not be the person you serve; the person who signs your contract is rarely the person whose trust you must win; and the instruction you receive at 9 a.m. from one may be reversed at 3 p.m. by the other.

3.2 · Who is who

Function	What they control, and what it means for you
Family office principal / CEO	Strategy and governance. You will rarely deal with them, and when you do it is significant.
Chief of staff	Where one exists, this is your true line manager. They own the operation. Win them, and you are safe. Bypass them, and you are finished.
Estate director / director of residences	Properties, projects, budgets, vendors. Your work will pass across their desk constantly.

Function	What they control, and what it means for you
Finance / controller	Payroll, expenses, budget approval. Your monthly reporting goes here. They will judge you on tidiness, and they speak to everyone.
Legal / general counsel	Contracts, NDAs, incidents. If you ever need them, you need them urgently, and knowing when to escalate is itself a professional skill.
Security director	Movements, vetting, residences, travel. Nothing you plan happens without them.

3.3 · The three questions of your first week

Answer these before you do anything ambitious. They are not administrative details; they are the political map of your working life.

- **Who signs?** Contracts, invoices, budget approvals. Usually the office.
- **Who decides?** On the day, in the house. Often the principal; often a spouse; sometimes a PA of fifteen years whom no one thought to put on the chart.
- **Whose trust must I win?** Frequently a third person entirely, and it is the answer that decides whether you are still here in two years.

3.4 · The contradiction, and the sentence that saves you

This is the most common structural failure in the profession, and it destroys perfectly competent people. The principal asks you for something. The office refuses it, or would refuse it if asked. Both consider themselves final. You are in the middle, and whichever way you move, you are wrong.

You do not choose a side. You do not quietly proceed and hope. You do not tell the principal that the office has refused, that is not your message to carry, and delivering it makes you the face of a refusal that is not yours.

THE SENTENCE

To the office: *"The principal has asked me for this. I want to make sure it is handled correctly, how would you like me to proceed?"*

You have now returned the decision to the person whose decision it is, and you have made yourself the person who handles things correctly. Both are true, and both are visible.

The staff member who resolves this alone, by guessing, is blamed by both sides. Always, and without exception.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Above roughly \$250M, a family office sits between you and the family.

Signing, deciding and trusting are three different people. Confusing them is the classic early error.

A contradiction between house and office is escalated, calmly and in writing, never resolved by guesswork.

CHAPTER IV

The household as an organisation

Stations, reporting lines, and the power map nobody draws

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Name every station in a private household and describe its remit.

Distinguish the formal organisation chart from the real distribution of influence.

Position yourself, as a newcomer, without provoking the people who can end you.

4.1 · The stations

Titles vary by country and by house. Functions do not. Learn them, and never step across a colleague's station without being invited.

Station	Remit
Principal	The person you serve. There may be two, and they may not want the same things.
Private / Executive PA	Diary, correspondence, travel, and the border between professional and private life. Your closest ally or your rival. Choose ally, early and deliberately.
House manager	One residence: staff, vendors, standards, provisions, the running of the day.
Estate manager	Several residences, or one very large one. Budgets, contractors, projects, teams. Senior.
Chief of staff	The strategic head of the private operation. Years of accumulated trust, never a certificate.
Butler	The dining room, the cellar, the service, often the supervision of others. Anticipation and discretion, not formality.
Head of housekeeping	The condition of the house, every day. She sees everything. Underestimate her and your first month becomes impossible.
Private chef	The table, provisioning, the family's dietary régime, and the guests' requirements. Guard this relationship: a chef who likes you will save you.
Nanny / governess	The children. In a great many houses, the single most trusted person in the building.

Station	Remit
Chauffeur	Timing, routes, privacy, the door opened at the exact moment. Far more than the car.
Close protection	Movements, vetting, guest lists, residences, travel. Nothing you plan happens without them.
Estate / grounds	Gardens, maintenance, the outbuildings, the systems. Quiet, long-serving, and they hear everything.

4.2 · The invisible hierarchy

The organisation chart is not the power map, and it never has been. The nanny who has the mother's ear may carry more weight than the estate manager. The chauffeur of fifteen years knows things the family office will never know. The head of housekeeping decides, in practice, whether your first month is pleasant or unsurvivable.

Influence in a household is a function of three things, and none of them appear on a chart: **tenure, proximity to the principal's body and children, and the possession of information.** Map these in your first month. Do it privately, and never speak of it.

4.3 · The position of the newcomer

You arrive as a threat. That is not paranoia; it is arithmetic. Every new hire implies that something was not working, and the people who were here before you know it. Your first month is not an audition of your competence, the family already believe you are competent, or they would not have hired you. It is an audition of your **character**, and the audience is the staff.

- Be early. Not on time, early. It is noticed once, and then assumed, and being assumed reliable is the whole game.
- Learn every name in the first week, including the gardener who comes on Tuesdays and the night security officer.
- Take the staff meal with the staff, at least at first. The person who eats alone from day one is the person nobody warns when something is about to go wrong.
- Change nothing for thirty days. Nothing, however obviously wrong it looks. The house has reasons you cannot see yet, and half of them are personal.
- Never criticise another member of staff to the principal, even when asked directly. Especially then: it is a test, whether or not they know it.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Know every station and its remit, and never cross one uninvited.

Influence flows from tenure, physical proximity to the family, and possession of information.

The newcomer is judged on character by the staff, and the staff are consulted.

CHAPTER V

The economics of the role

What it pays, what drives the number, and the shape of a career

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

State the indicative compensation bands for each role, and the factors that move them.

Read a package rather than a salary.

Describe a realistic ten-year trajectory in this profession.

5.1 · Indicative bands

The figures below are drawn from the 2026 private staff salary guides published by the specialist agencies of this sector, and from live agency briefs. They are a guide to the shape of the market, not a promise, and they vary enormously with residences, travel, languages, and the sensitivity of the household. Treat any single number in this profession with suspicion, including these.

Role	Indicative annual range (2026)
Guest relations / villa or chalet host	\$55k to \$120k, frequently seasonal, and often with accommodation provided
Private concierge / lifestyle manager	\$70k to \$150k+ (US) · £60k to £110k+ (UK and Europe)
Private / executive PA to a UHNW principal	up to \$250k at the top of the US market · £70k to £100k+ (UK)
House manager	\$110k to \$190k in New York, the Hamptons and Palm Beach · £75k to £115k (UK)
Estate manager	median \$185k, top quartile \$260k+ (US) · £110k to £220k+ (UK)
Chief of staff (private household)	\$150k to \$350k+
Yacht / private aviation interior	\$50k to \$130k+, structured by rotation

Two further facts, and they are the reason this profession is worth entering now. Estate manager pay has risen by **twenty to thirty per cent since 2022**. Demand for private assistants to UHNW principals has risen by **twenty-five to thirty per cent** over the same period. The supply of people who can genuinely be trusted has not moved at all.

5.2 · Read the package, not the salary

A stated salary in this field is frequently the smaller part of the story. Two offers that appear \$30,000 apart can be identical, or the reverse.

- **Accommodation.** Live-in, a cottage on the estate, or a rented flat paid for. Where it is provided on the estate it is commonly valued at \$30k to \$45k a year, and in Monaco, Geneva or London it can be worth far more.
- **Vehicle.** Provided, or an allowance, or nothing.
- **Travel.** Whether you fly with the family, and in what class, and who pays for your journey home on your days off.
- **Health cover and pension.** Enormously variable by country, and frequently the single largest hidden difference.
- **Bonus.** Discretionary in nearly every house. Ask how it has been paid in the last three years, not how it is described.
- **The rota.** Five days? Six? On call? Two weeks on, two off? This is not a benefit, it is the shape of your life, and it should be the first thing you negotiate and the last thing you concede.

5.3 · What actually drives the number

Driver	Effect
Number of residences	The strongest single driver. Each additional property adds vendors, budgets, staff and travel.
Staff supervised	A role that manages people is paid on a different scale from one that does not. This is the step-change in a career.
Languages	French, Italian, Spanish, Arabic, Russian, Mandarin. Each is a genuine multiplier in the right household.
Mobility	The willingness to relocate or to travel at short notice is priced, and priced well.
Sensitivity	Houses with unusual exposure, political, media, security, pay a premium for people who can carry it. The premium is real, and so is the cost.

Driver**Effect**

Tenure and reference	After the first role, you are paid for your reputation. This is why the first role matters mainly as a source of the second.
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5.4 · The trajectory

A realistic shape, and you should hold it in mind rather than the fantasy, because the fantasy is what makes people quit in year two.

Stage**What it looks like**

Years 0 to 2	The first role, very often below your ambition. Seasonal, or junior, or in a house that is not glamorous. Be impeccable in it. Its purpose is not the salary; its purpose is the reference.
Years 2 to 5	The second role, obtained largely on the strength of the first. Now the money moves. You begin to specialise, and the agencies begin to call you rather than the reverse.
Years 5 to 10	Seniority. You manage people, budgets, and projects. You are approached before roles are advertised, and the best positions in this field are never advertised at all.
Years 10+	Estate manager, chief of staff, or your own practice. Very few reach it, and those who do got there by never once damaging their name.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The bands are wide, and the package matters more than the salary.

Residences, staff, languages, mobility and sensitivity drive the number.

The first role is not the destination. It is the reference that buys the second, which is where the career actually begins.

CHAPTER VI

The service model

Time, peace, discretion, and the request beneath the request

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Apply the three-lever test to any action before you take it.

Unlearn the hospitality reflex, and know precisely why it is dangerous here.

Decompress a request without pushing the work back onto the principal.

6.1 · The triad

They are not buying a service. They can buy any service on earth with a telephone call. They are buying three things, and they are buying them from you personally, because they cannot be bought from a company.

TIME · PEACE · DISCRETION

Time. Their day has twenty-four hours and far more claims on it than yours. Every decision you remove is time returned. This is measurable, and it is what justifies your salary.

Peace. Not the absence of problems, the absence of the *feeling* of problems. A crisis you resolved and never mentioned did not occur. A crisis you resolved and then recounted in detail did occur, and you created it.

Discretion. The permanent certainty that nothing about their life will leak, be sold, be posted, or become dinner-party currency. This is the one they can never verify, and therefore the one they watch most closely.

The test. Before any action: does this give them time, peace, or silence? If it gives them none of the three, you are decorating, not serving, and decoration in a private house is not neutral. It is noise, and noise is a cost.

6.2 · The hospitality reflex

In a hotel

You are rewarded for what the guest notices.

In a house

You are rewarded for what the principal never has to notice.

In a hotel

The flourish is the product. The upgrade is announced.

The guest leaves in three days; you must be memorable.

Warmth is expressed.

Recovery is public: the apology, the compensation, the letter.

In a house

The flourish is an intrusion. The upgrade is simply there.

The principal stays for years; you must be inevitable.

Warmth is felt, and rarely expressed.

Recovery is invisible: it was handled before it arrived at their door.

This inversion is the hardest habit any hotelier has to unlearn, and it takes most people the better part of a year. The family will feel it long before they can name it. They will simply find you slightly *tiring*, and they will not be able to say why.

6.3 · A taxonomy of requests

Type**How it is handled**

Routine	The reservation, the car, the delivery, the appointment. Handled without conversation. If a routine request requires a conversation, your systems are wrong.
Exceptional	The table that is full, the aircraft on four hours' notice, the piece that is sold out. This is where your black book earns its keep, and where you are visibly worth your salary.
Impossible	It cannot be done. Say so, immediately, and arrive with the two best alternatives already secured. The professional is not the one who never fails; it is the one who never leaves a vacuum.
Improper	It should not be done. This is the category nobody trains you for, and the one that ends careers. Chapter IX and Module 2 are devoted to it.

6.4 · The request beneath the request

A request is almost never what it says. It is the visible tip of a need, and it arrives compressed, half-formed, and at an inconvenient hour. Your work is to decompress it **without asking the principal to do that work for you**. Every question you ask is a small tax on their attention, and four questions is an insult dressed as diligence.

WORKED EXAMPLE

21:04, Tuesday. The message reads, in full: *“Do we still have that restaurant in Rome?”*

The beginner replies: Which restaurant? What date? For how many? Will Mr, be joining?, Four taxes on the principal’s evening, and no progress whatsoever.

The professional does five things before replying. Reads the diary: Rome, Thursday. Reads the preference file: the restaurant, the table by the window, the two who dined there in March. Calls the restaurant: full. Calls the maître d’ she has cultivated for two years, precisely for an evening like this one: not full. Holds two times.

Then replies, once: *“Yes. Thursday, 8pm or 9.30pm, whichever suits. I have kept both.”*

One question remains, and it is easy to answer. That sentence is the entire profession in a single line.

Notice what made it possible, because none of it was improvisation: a diary that was read, a preference file that was maintained, and a relationship that was built long before the night it was needed. **Anticipation is not a gift. It is infrastructure.**

6.5 · Two standing principles

- **No surprises.** Not to the principal, not to the office, not to your line manager. A bad fact delivered early is a manageable fact. The same fact delivered late is a crisis, and the crisis is now about you.
- **Never become the single point of failure.** It is tempting to hold everything in your own head, the passwords, the contacts, the arrangements, because it feels like security. It is the opposite. Families do not reward staff who cannot be replaced; they fear them, and fear leads to a quiet reduction of your access. The people who last document everything so well that they could be replaced tomorrow, and are, for exactly that reason, never replaced.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Every action must buy time, peace or discretion. Otherwise it is decoration.

Hotel instincts reward visibility; private service rewards invisibility. Unlearn it deliberately.

Requests are routine, exceptional, impossible, or improper. The fourth is the one that ends careers.

Decompress the request yourself. The number of questions in your reply is your professional signature.

CHAPTER VII

The principal

A working psychological profile

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Explain why decision fatigue governs almost everything about how you communicate.

Understand privacy as a security condition rather than a preference.

Recognise the confidante trap before you are in it.

7.1 · Decision fatigue

They make consequential decisions all day, and the supply of that capacity is finite. Therefore: **never bring them a decision they did not need to make**. Bring two options and a recommendation, or bring nothing at all and tell them afterwards. The staff member who arrives with an open question is asking to be paid for work they have not done.

7.2 · The asymmetry

Almost every person in their life wants something: an investment, an introduction, a job, a donation, an association, a story. They have been asked for something by nearly everyone they have ever met, including people who claimed to want nothing.

The consequence is the deepest source of your professional value: **the person who asks for nothing becomes precious**. And it explains a rule that seems severe until you understand it, never ask the principal for a favour. Not an introduction, not a recommendation for your cousin, not a ticket, not advice on your own investments. The moment you ask, you have joined the several thousand people who want something, and you can never leave that category again.

7.3 · Privacy is safety

What feels like secrecy to you is, to them, the thin membrane between their children and a real risk. Their address, their movements, the school run, the make of the car, the week the house is empty. Kidnap and extortion are not abstractions in this world; they are a line item in the security budget, and the security director you find tiresome is the person who

has read the threat assessment that you have not.

Understand this and you will never again be careless with an itinerary, a photograph, or a supplier who “just needs to know when the family will be away”.

7.4 · Loneliness, and the confidante trap

They are frequently lonely inside their own house, surrounded, and alone. You will be present at the difficult moments, because you are always present. One evening, tired, they will tell you something they should not have told you, and the next morning they will be formal and brisk as though it never occurred.

That evening is not an invitation to intimacy. It is a debt of discretion, and it is the heaviest one you will carry. The following morning you are exactly as you were before: warm, professional, entirely unchanged. You do not soften your voice. You do not offer the sympathetic look. You never refer to it again unless they do.

Being trusted feels like being chosen. It is not. It is a professional condition, not a personal one. The staff member who becomes a confidante is, in time, quietly moved on, because they have become a witness, and nobody wishes to live alongside a witness.

7.5 · Two principals, and the children

- **Where there are two principals, they do not always want the same thing.** You will be caught between them, and it will be over something small. Serve both, favour neither, and never carry a message that has an edge on it. If asked to keep something from the other, decline gently and immediately, before it becomes a pattern you cannot escape.
- **The children are not your friends, and they are not your charges** unless you are the nanny. Be warm, be consistent, be entirely uninvolved in discipline, and never, under any circumstances, become the adult a child confides in about their parents.
- **An ex-spouse is a permanent structural hazard.** Information, schedules, and the children. Ask the office, once, what your instruction is, and then follow it exactly.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Never bring a decision they did not need to make.

The person who asks for nothing is precious. Never ask for a favour.

Privacy is a security condition, not a preference.

Trust is professional, not personal. The confidante becomes a witness, and the witness is moved on.

CHAPTER VIII

The year

The calendar these families live by

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Reproduce the seasonal calendar of the UHNW world from memory.

Time your applications to the hiring seasons rather than to your own impatience.

Schedule house projects into the windows when the family is away.

Nobody teaches this, and everyone senior simply knows it. These families move on a calendar, and the calendar is remarkably stable from year to year. Learn it and you become useful in your first month rather than your sixth.

Period	Where the world is
December, March	The Alps. Gstaad, Courchevel, Verbier, St Moritz, Zermatt, Aspen. Chalet and villa staff are recruited in September and October, and again, in panic, in late November.
January	Davos. The art and auction calendar begins. School terms govern everything where there are children, and they govern it absolutely.
April, May	The Riviera reopens; the villas are prepared. The Monaco Grand Prix makes the entire coast unbookable for a fortnight. Easter, and the first openings.
June, August	The Mediterranean. Saint-Tropez, Sardinia, Ibiza, the Greek islands, the yachts. The Hamptons for American families. Peak demand, peak improvisation, and the season in which reputations are made and lost.
September	The return. City, school, and the beginning of the works that were saved for the empty months.
October, November	Art fairs, auctions, the philanthropic season, the galas. Winter staff are hired now, and the good roles are gone by mid-November.

TWO PRACTICAL CONSEQUENCES

Hiring. Seasonal roles, the most realistic first rung for a newcomer, are filled three to four months in advance. If you apply in December for a winter season, you are applying for next year, and you did not know it.

Projects. Moves, renovations, deep cleans and installations are scheduled into the weeks the family is away. The empty house is not your quiet period. It is your busiest, and it is where your real work is done and seen.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The UHNW year is stable and knowable. Learn it before your first interview.

Seasonal roles are filled three to four months ahead.

The family's absence is your working season, not your holiday.

CHAPTER IX

Failure

How careers end in this profession, and how they are saved

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

List the five causes of dismissal, and recognise that none is technical.

Detect the early signals that a household is withdrawing from you.

Handle your own error in the ninety minutes that decide everything.

9.1 · The five dismissals

Note what is absent from this list: technical incompetence. By the time you are hired, competence is assumed. You will not be dismissed for failing to secure a table. You will be dismissed for one of these five.

Cause	Why it is fatal
Indiscretion	However small, however innocent. A photograph, a name, a story told to one friend. It is the fastest, and it is final, and it is unforgiven because it cannot be undone.
A lie about a mistake	Never the mistake itself. Every house has seen a hundred errors. What no house forgives is the discovery that it was softened, delayed or managed. Once they believe you manage them, everything you say is re-read.
Familiarity	The slow drift from professional to friend. It feels like success. It is the beginning of the end: they cannot manage a friend, and they will not dismiss one, they will simply find less and less for you to do.
Making them feel a burden	A sigh. A hesitation. A visible calculation before you answer. It will never be mentioned to you, and it will never be forgotten.
Visible fatigue or complaint	The hours are genuinely hard. Carrying that privately is part of what you are paid for. Complain to your partner, your friends, your mentor. Never in the house, and never to another member of staff.

9.2 · The early signals

A household almost never dismisses without a period of withdrawal first. Learn to read it, because it is recoverable if you catch it early and almost never recoverable once it is complete.

- You are told things later than you used to be.
- A task you used to own is given, without explanation, to someone else.
- The principal begins to copy the office on messages that used to come to you alone.
- An outside supplier is engaged for something you would have handled.
- Politeness increases and warmth decreases. In this world, that combination is the loudest possible signal.

If you see two of these, do not become anxious and do not become obsequious, both accelerate it. Ask for ten minutes, and ask one question: *“Is there anything you would like me to be doing differently?”* Then listen without defending. The single most common reason a household lets someone go is that they never asked.

9.3 · The ninety minutes after your own error

You will make a serious mistake. The flight on the wrong day; the guest who was not on the list; the payment that did not go. What is tested is not the error. It is the ninety minutes that follow it.

THE PROTOCOL

1. **Establish the facts.** Precisely, quickly, without speculation. What is true, what is not yet known.
2. **Build the remedy before you speak.** What are the actual options now? Arrive with the problem *and* two solutions, and a recommendation. If you have none, you are not ready to have the conversation.
3. **Tell them the same day.** Plainly: *“I made an error with the date. Here is where we are, here are the two ways forward, and I recommend the first.”*
4. **Never use the passive voice.** “The booking was made incorrectly” is a lie wearing grammar. They will hear it, and they will hear it as a lie.
5. **Then fix the system, not the incident,** and tell them what you have changed. That sentence is what converts an error into a reason to trust you more than before.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Nobody is dismissed for incompetence. They are dismissed for indiscretion, for concealment, for familiarity, for burdening, or for complaint.

Withdrawal precedes dismissal, and it is legible. Politeness up, warmth down.

Own an error the same day, with the remedy already in motion, in the active voice.

Glossary of the module

Principal, The individual served. The correct and only term in a private household.

Family office, The private structure managing a family's wealth and affairs; frequently the legal employer of household staff.

SFO / MFO, Single-family office (one family) / multi-family office (several).

Chief of staff, The senior head of a private operation, above estate and house management.

Estate manager, Manager of one or several residences: staff, budgets, contractors, standards.

House manager, Manager of a single residence and its daily running.

Preference file, The structured record of a principal's preferences, aversions, people and dates. The central instrument of anticipation.

Black book, The private register of trusted suppliers and contacts, built over years and never lent.

Rota, The staff schedule: duty, cover, rotation, time off.

Live-in / live-out, Whether accommodation is provided. It changes the role, the pay, and the life.

Close protection, The security detail around a principal and their family.

NDA, Non-disclosure agreement. The floor of discretion, never its standard.

The triad, Time, peace, discretion, the three things a principal is actually buying.

Improper request, A request that should not be fulfilled, distinct from one that cannot be. The category that ends careers.

Self-assessment

Answer in writing, without returning to the text. If you cannot answer eight of these, read the module again before you begin Module 3.

1. Name the three things a principal is actually buying, and rank them for a first-generation technology entrepreneur. Defend the order.
2. What are the two questions you ask at interview, and what does each reveal?
3. A principal asks you for something the family office would refuse. What is the exact sentence you use, and to whom?
4. Give three sources of influence in a household that do not appear on the organisation chart.
5. What is the difference between an impossible request and an improper one? Give an example of each.
6. You discover at 23:00 that you booked tomorrow's flight on the wrong day. Describe your next ninety minutes, in order.
7. Why must you never ask the principal for a favour? Answer in terms of the asymmetry.
8. What five signals suggest a household is withdrawing from you?
9. When are winter chalet roles recruited, and what does that mean for your applications?
10. Explain the "single point of failure" error, and why holding all the information is a professional weakness rather than a strength.
11. Why is the hospitality reflex dangerous in a private house? Give two concrete behaviours you must unlearn.
12. The principal confides something painful late one evening. Describe your conduct the following morning, in detail.

Further study

None of the following is required. All of it will make you better, and it is the kind of reading that shows in a conversation.

- **Read the agency briefs, weekly.** Morgan & Mallet, Silver Swan, Tiger, Career Group, The Calendar Group. Not to apply, to learn the language in which this world describes what it wants. Read fifty of them and you will write a CV that fits the field without being told how.
- **Read the wealth reports.** The annual UHNW population and geography studies published by the large property and consulting firms. You will learn where the money is going, which is where the roles are going.
- **Read one serious book on the history of service,** the great household, the butler tradition, the brigade. It will give you the lineage of every word you use.
- **Follow the calendar.** The Monaco Grand Prix, Art Basel, the auction seasons, the school terms of the great schools. Know when the world moves.
- **Study the Dictionary of Luxury,** which accompanies this programme, entry by entry. Week Two will assume it.

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